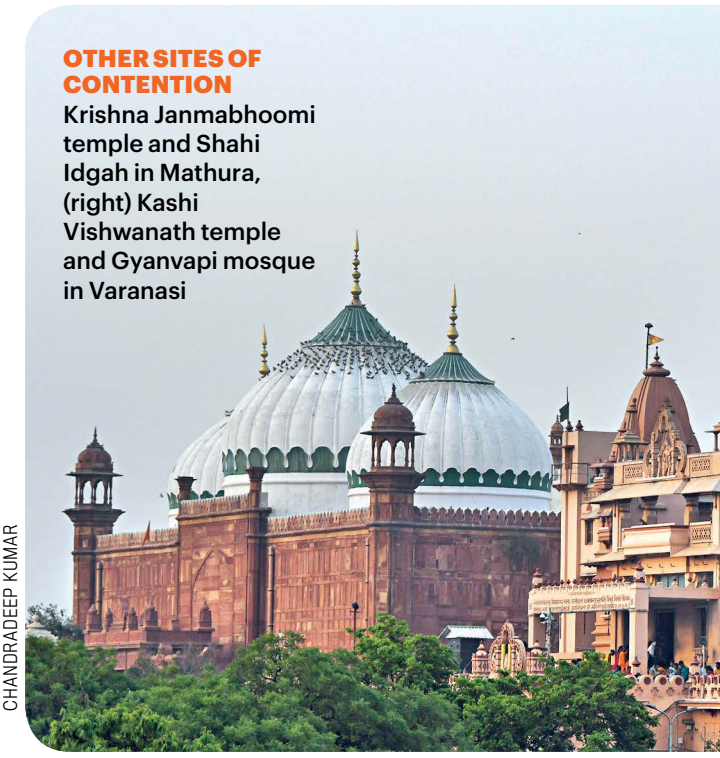




OTHER SITES OF CONTENTION
Krishna Janmabhoomi temple and Shahi Idgah in Mathura, (right) Kashi Vishwanath temple and Gyanvapi mosque in Varanasi

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Political experts saw it as the prime minister's way to counter the Opposition criticism that he had converted the whole event into self-glorification and idolatry of himself. The Opposition itself was caught on the back foot when they were invited to attend the consecration. If they didn't accept, they ran the risk of the BJP accusing them of being anti-Hindu; if they did go, it would be endorsing the BJP's role in building the Ram temple in Ayodhya. In the end, most of them, including the Congress, stayed away from the ceremony, criticising Modi for politicising the event and claiming that they would pay their respects at an appropriate time. Odisha chief minister Naveen Patnaik took the smartest route by inaugurating the total revamp of the Jagannath Puri temple complex days before the Ram Mandir event, establishing himself as an equally capable defender of the faith (see accompanying report, *The Puri Makeover*).

SHUNNING TRIUMPHALISM

To their credit, both Bhagwat and Modi in their speeches shunned triumphalism. Calling for national unity, Bhagwat said, "We must maintain good conduct and end disputes. We must stop the habit of fighting over things and learn to live in harmony." He saw the construction of the temple as the rise of "a New Bharat" and foretold that "Ram Rajya was coming". The RSS chief also said that the nation should be seen "moving forward with truth, compassion, wisdom and charity". The prime minister turned lyrical in his stirring speech, saying, "This is a temple of national consciousness. Ram is the faith, the foundation of India, the idea of India, the law of India, the consciousness of India and the glory of India. Ram is both the flow and the effect. There is Ram *neti* (analysis through negation), there is also Ram *neeti* (principled decisions). Ram is eternal but also continuity." Then, he turned statesman-like and invoked Viksit Bharat, the goal of a developed nation by 2047, saying it was time all Indians took a pledge to "build a strong, capable, grand and divine India".

Without doubt, the construction of the temple and consecration of the Ram idol are not just a symbol of the grand revival of Hinduism across the country but will also have a profound impact on India's future. Experts see plenty of positives and matters of concern. Dattatreya Hosabale, the erudite Sarkaryavah (General Secretary) of the RSS, sees the Ram Mandir as a major inflection point in the nation's history. As he puts it, "The whole movement of Ram Jamnabhoomi was started to strengthen national unity and self-respect and to restate the civilisational aspect of our nation. What we are seeing on the horizon is a new civilisation paradigm for the modern times based on cultural heritage. The very word 'Ram' is unifying for all strata of society and all religions within Bharat."

Other experts are uncomfortable with the blurring of lines between spiritual and temporal powers and see the strengthening of Mandir politics as a blow to India's secular ethos. Political activist Yogendra Yadav believes "it's a conscious attempt to create a Hindu political community that has never existed in this country. A community that is homogeneous, where the sects do not matter. It doesn't cut across but papers over caste. It's an astoundingly brilliant attempt but also diabolic. It's the first attempt to reverse the relationship between the State and Dharma. It's the first attempt to colonise Hinduism by political power." Adds social anthropologist Shiv Visvanathan, "To call the Mandir a new kind of resurgence does not fit history but advertising. This is not a Bhakti movement of any kind. This is an attempt to use religion instrumentally. The syncretic power of religion, the dialogicity is lost. The current story lacks the subtlety and suppleness of a narrative. It sounds more like a diktat."

TO DISPEL THE NOTION THAT HIS INTENTION WAS 'ONE NATION, ONE GOD', THE PM WENT ON A TEMPLE RUN IN BOTH THE WEST AND THE SOUTH PRIOR TO AYODHYA